17

1922, Chauri Chaura

Indian revolutionaries got their chance to show their mettle with the violent Chauri Chaura incident in what is now Uttar Pradesh (previously United Provinces). It began on 2 February 1922. Large numbers of volunteers were participating in a protest against high food prices. Although led by a retired Army soldier, Bhagwan Ahir, it was part of Gandhi's non-cooperation movement. When this happened, the police not only beat them back but also arrested several of their leaders and locked them up at the Chauri Chaura police station. On 4 February, two days later, protestors set out to demonstrate against police brutality at the local marketplace. They ended up clashing with the police, who fired on them. Angry rioters soon attacked the police station and set fire to it. Not only were three civilians killed, but twenty-three policemen were also burnt alive in the police station. Ever the one to appease British sentiments, Mahatma Gandhi called off the non-cooperation movement a week later on 12 February 1922. In doing so, he consulted no one in the executive committee of the Congress Party and he ascertained no facts as to what exactly happened. Many in the Congress Party felt deceived and abandoned. To call off the non-cooperation movement just as it was beginning to bear fruit was unwarranted. As Professor Tim Murphy points out in his recent magnum opus '[t]o many nationalists this was precisely the problem: that the means might stifle the end,' and for some like the Bengal Congress leader, C.R. Das, 'this was a rejection of politics itself.'[1] In fact, the *Times of India* recently recounted of the Chauri Chaura incident that, '[t]he atrocity might have remained one unsavoury event in the freedom struggle, had Gandhi not unilaterally called off the struggle' because in doing so he had 'disavowed the peasants who